

**"IN A SICK SOCIETY,  
WOMEN WHO HAVE  
DIFFICULTY FITTING  
IN ARE NOT ILL."**

CHARLOTTE PERKINS GILMAN, AUTHOR OF *THE YELLOW WALLPAPER*, 1892



formed the basis for private madhouses. The move from charitable care to profit-oriented containment meant that asylums became a useful "dumping ground" for those who did not comply with societal

norms, be they radicals, heretics, or women. The madhouse provided the means of controlling such people.

In 18th-century Europe, the prevalent wisdom was that if a husband could not control his deviant wife within the institution of marriage, the madhouse was an option. Until 1774, there was no onus on husbands to prove their wives' so-called madness—they could simply deposit them at the institution indefinitely. Husbands (or fathers) had women committed for reasons such as "deranged masturbation," "political excitement," and "excessive reading" as well as symptoms of mental illnesses such as depression and anxiety. Other times admitting a woman to an asylum was simply orchestrated as a means to gain control of her estate, as an alternative to divorce, or as a way to make a woman compliant.

### Horrors of the asylum

Women were kept in terrible conditions in stinking, overcrowded cells, and suffered brutality and sexual violence. One of the most infamous asylums was Bedlam (Bethlem Royal Hospital) in London. By the end of the 19th century, there were so many stories of wrongful confinement that journalist Nelly Bly spent 10 days in New York's Blackwell Island to expose the abuses. The most chilling aspect of her story was that, once committed, she returned to normal "sane" behavior, but her warders were incapable of recognizing it as such. For a wrongfully committed woman, even a sane one, there was no escape from the system.

### ▼ Portrait of pain

This female inmate of Surrey County Asylum, UK, was photographed in 1855 by Dr. Hugh Welch Diamond, who captured many such portraits of mentally ill women in public asylums. He ceased photography after founding a private institution in 1858.

